FREE!

The Guided Planet

ISSUE 002 DECEMBER 2026 THE REAL OR PRETEND EDITION AGES 7 TO 12 AND THEIR GROWN UPS

Free to print and keep

Real or pretend?

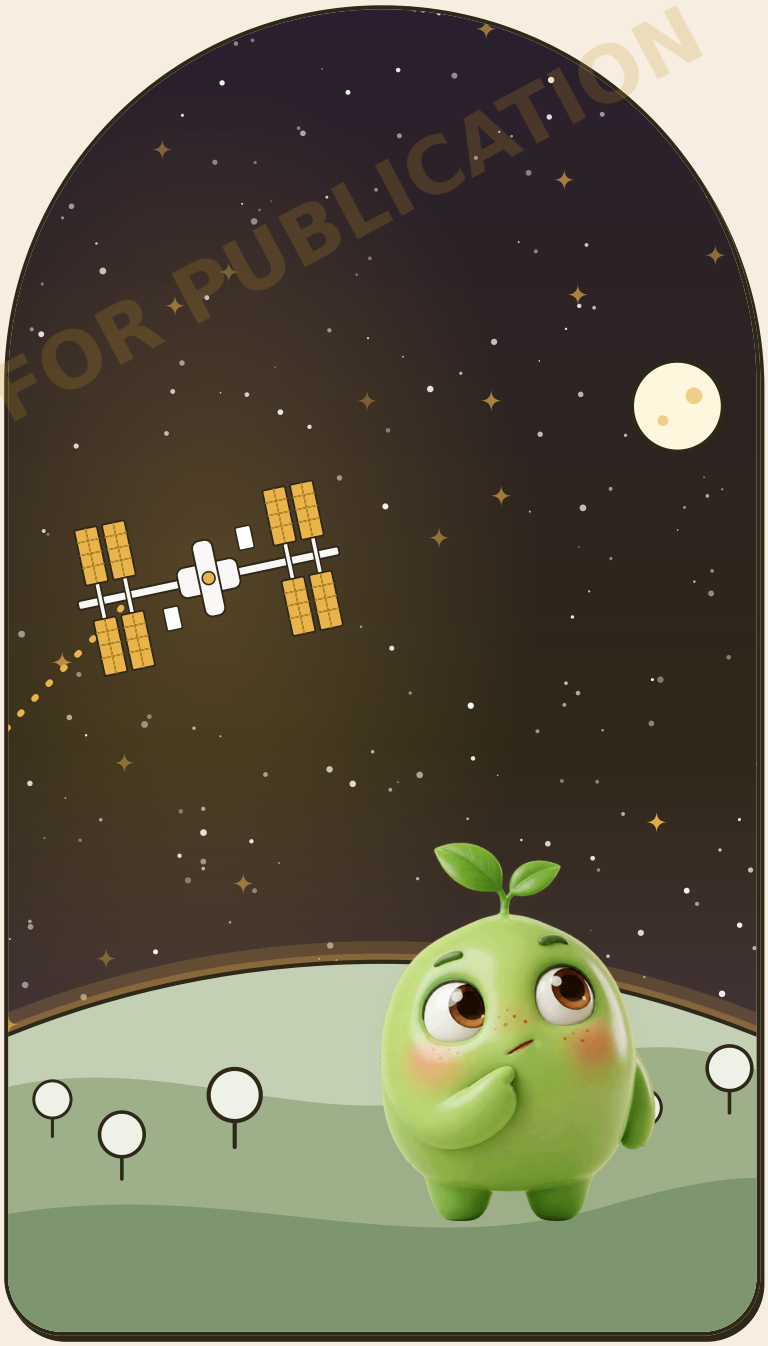
This month: how to check a picture, a game of real or pretend, and a detective kit for anything you see online.

3 How to check a picture

5 Design a fake detector

8 Bloop investigates

9 Real or Pretend cards



SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

A little more wonder. A lot more understanding.

From the editor's desk

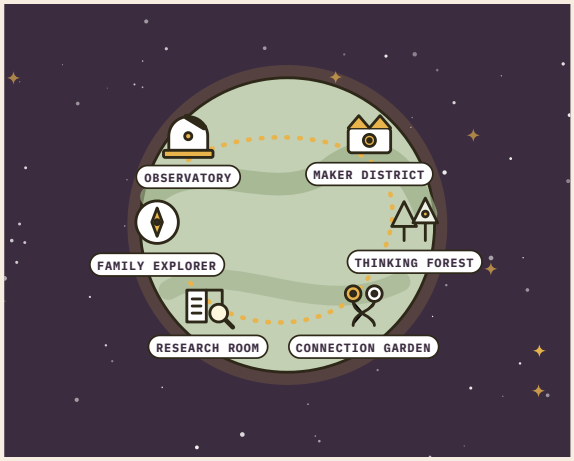
Welcome back, explorers

This month is all about one question: is it real, or is it pretend? Pictures, videos and stories can be made by people, by computers, or by both, and it is not always easy to tell.

You do not need to be a scientist to check something. You need a few good questions and the patience to ask them. This paper is full of those questions.

As always, none of the activities need a phone or an account.

Justin Phillips
EDITOR IN CHIEF, THE GUIDED PLANET



YOUR MAP: SIX PLACES TO EXPLORE, EVERY ISSUE

Inside this issue

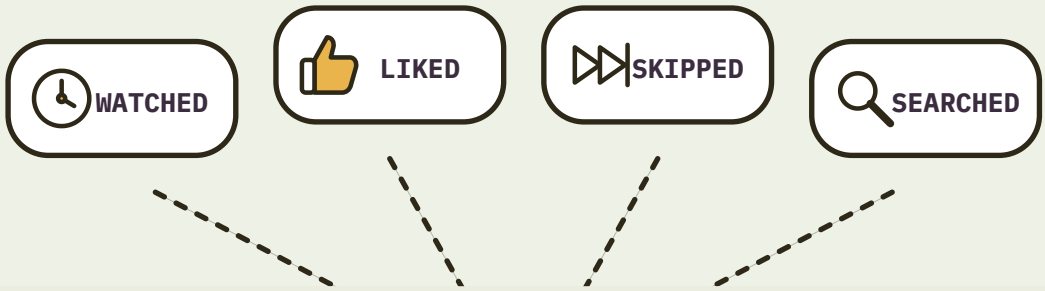
3 How to check a picture
4 Young fact checkers
5 Design a fake detector
6 What research says about spotting fakes
7 Kind words travel too
8 Bloop investigates
9 Real or Pretend cards
10 Five good things
11 Seven days of checking
12 Your Planet Passport

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION



Bloop says

I once thought a picture of a cat in a spacesuit was real. It was not. Let's get better at this together.



THE THINKING FOREST

Thinking Forest

How to check a picture

Four questions to ask before you believe, or share, a picture you have found.

Who made it? Look for the name of a person or an organisation you could check.

Where else is it? If something amazing happened, more than one trusted place will usually say so.

Does anything look odd? Hands, writing and shadows are good places to look closely.

How does it make you feel? Pictures made to shock or to rush you deserve a slower look.

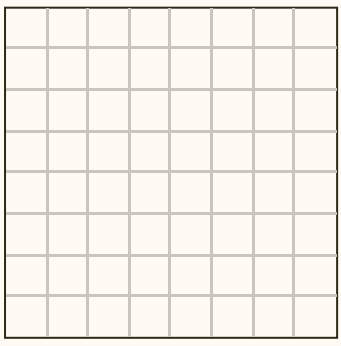
SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION



Orbit says

My magnifier is enormous, but the best tool is a question.

ACTIVITY · NO SCREEN NEEDED



64 SQUARES · 8 ACROSS · 8 DOWN

Hide a mistake

Draw a picture on the grid with one thing wrong in it. Can a grown up spot it?

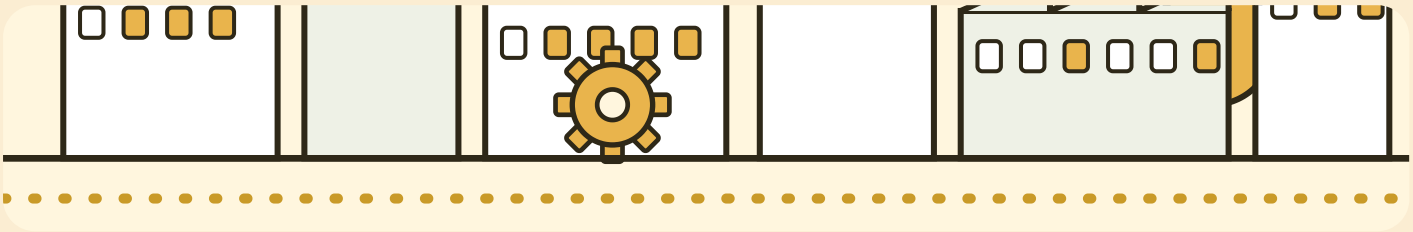
1. Draw something simple, like a house or a face.
2. Add one mistake, like a window in the sky.
3. Swap with someone and spot each other's mistake.

BUTTER · LEAF · SKY · NIGHT

THE MAKER DISTRICT *Young inventors*

Young fact checkers

Story to be researched in week one and verified before print.



This page will carry projects by young people who built tools to check what is real. They are chosen at approval one.

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

Project one

BY TO BE CHOSEN · APPROVAL ONE

Story to be researched in week one and verified before print.

Placeholder.

Project two

BY TO BE CHOSEN · APPROVAL ONE

Story to be researched in week one and verified before print.

Placeholder.

Project three

BY TO BE CHOSEN · APPROVAL ONE

Story to be researched in week one and verified before print.

Placeholder.

Project four

BY TO BE CHOSEN · APPROVAL ONE

Story to be researched in week one and verified before print.

Placeholder.

THE MAKER DISTRICT

Your turn

Design a fake detector

Invent a gadget that helps people check what they see. Start with the person it helps.



Bloop says

Mine beeps when a picture has six fingers. It also beeps at gloves. Work in progress.

ACTIVITY · NO SCREEN NEEDED

My fake detector

Fill in each box and draw big.

01 · DRAW IT

Draw your detector and label every part.

02 · WHO IT HELPS

Who gets fooled, and when?

03 · WHAT IT CHECKS

Hands, shadows, writing, where it came from?

04 · WHAT IT NOTICES

What clue does it look for?

05 · WHAT IT DOES BACK

A light, a sound, a message?

06 · NAME IT

A name worth remembering.

07 · TEST IT

How would you know it works?

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

MAKER TIPS

- Test it on real and pretend pictures you made yourself.
- A good detector says how sure it is, not just yes or no.

THE RESEARCH ROOM *What scientists know*

What research says about spotting fakes

Story to be researched in week one and verified before print.

Pictures
Photos and drawings.

To be researched.

Videos
Clips and shorts.

To be researched.

Stories
News and posts.

To be researched.

Voices
Audio and songs.

To be researched.

WHAT THE RESEARCH FOUND	Story to be researched in week one and verified before print.
WHAT IT CANNOT TELL US YET	Placeholder for the limits of the evidence, written once the evidence is in.

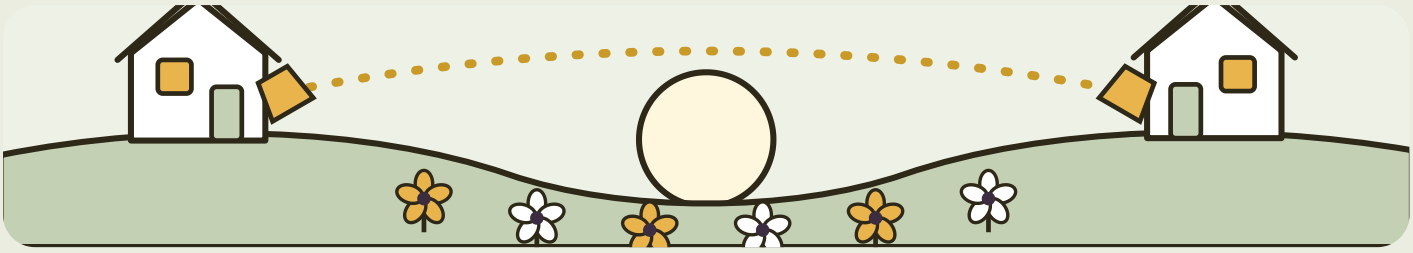
Talk about it together

1. Have you ever been fooled by a picture?
2. What made you realise?

DiGi says

We print what the evidence says, and we say what it cannot tell us.

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION



THE CONNECTION GARDEN *Friendship*

Kind words travel too

A kind message can be checked for one thing only: did it make someone's day?

Checking what is real matters. So does being someone people can trust online. When you share something, you are lending it your name.

If you are not sure something is true, it is fine not to pass it on. Waiting is a kind thing to do.

Before you share

- Is it true?
- Is it kind?
- Would I say it to their face?



Pebble says

I turn things the right way round before I share them.

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

ACTIVITY · NO SCREEN NEEDED

Send a true thing

Write a postcard about something true and good that happened this month.

DRAW THE TRUE AND GOOD THING

DEAR _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Post it with a grown up · Or hand it over

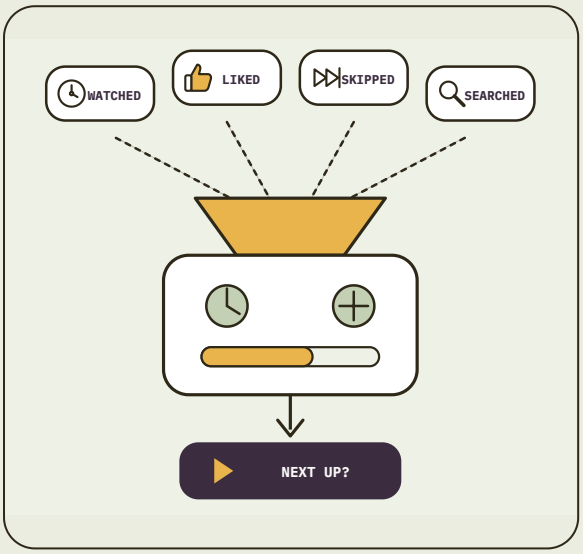
THE THINKING FOREST

Bloop investigates

Was this picture made by a computer?

Bloop found a picture of a dog surfing a rainbow. Time for some clues.





Bloop's verdict

Case closed: no single clue proves it. Lots of clues together make a good guess, and a grown up can help you check.

An algorithm is a list of steps for solving a problem.[1] Some computers follow steps that make pictures, and some follow steps that recommend what to watch next.[2]

CLUE 1 — Look at the edges
Are there odd blurs or shapes where things meet?

CLUE 2 — Look at the details
Hands, teeth, writing and patterns can go wrong.

CLUE 3 — Look for the maker
Who posted it first, and do they say how it was made?

CLUE 4 — Look around
Does anyone trusted show the same thing?

Try this, no account needed

- Make a picture yourself, then ask a grown up to guess how you made it.
- Play Real or Pretend on the next page.

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

Where this came from

1 **BBC Bitesize**, What is an algorithm?. bbc.co.uk
2 **YouTube Help**, How YouTube recommendations work. support.google.com

THE THINKING FOREST

A paper game

Real or Pretend

One player is the Maker, one is the Detective. Can the Detective tell which cards are real?



Bloop says

I was the Detective and I said everything was pretend. That is not detecting, apparently.

Players · 2 to 6

You need: the 12 cards, a pencil, the notebook below.

Set up

1. Cut out the 12 cards and shuffle them.
2. The Maker secretly marks some cards REAL and some PRETEND on the back.
3. Deal three cards face up.

Play five rounds

1. The Detective asks one question about a card.
2. The Maker answers truthfully.
3. The Detective says real or pretend, and checks the back.
4. After round five, swap jobs.

Then talk about it

- Which questions helped most?
- Which cards fooled you, and why?

CUT OUT THE 12 VIDEO CARDS

Surfing dog ANIMALS	Sleeping cat ANIMALS	Moon base SPACE
Rocket launch SPACE	Huge goal SPORT	Team photo SPORT
Painted dragon ART	Clay owl ART	Robot band MUSIC
School choir MUSIC	Giant cake FOOD	Pizza face FOOD

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

The Algorithm's notebook

	ROUND 1	ROUND 2	ROUND 3	ROUND 4	ROUND 5
WATCHED					
SKIPPED					
MY GUESS					

GOING FURTHER

- Make your own cards from pictures you drew yourself.

THE FAMILY EXPLORER *Five good things*

Five good things to explore together

Checked for this issue. Look again together before signing up for anything.



Orbit says

Same five places as last month, because they are still good. The list changes when something better comes along.

1 micro:bit MakeCode

Free, open source block coding for the BBC micro:bit, with a simulator that shows what your program will do. [1]

New this year: screen reader support for block coding, shaped with blind and low vision young people. [2]

WHO FOR Beginners, with a grown up
ACCOUNT Ask a grown up
`makecode.microbit.org`

2 Scratch

Snap code blocks together to make games, stories and animations. Free for everyone. [4]

Start small: make a cat move, then make it dance.

WHO FOR Ages 8 to 16 [3]
ACCOUNT Ask a grown up first
`scratch.mit.edu`

3 ESA Kids

Space news, facts, animations and downloads from the European Space Agency. [5]

Liked page 3? Find out more about life in space.

WHO FOR Ages 6 to 12 [5]
ACCOUNT None
`www.esa.int/kids/en/home`

4 Night sky highlights

Free guides from Royal Museums Greenwich to what is up in the sky. [6]

Looking up needs no screen at all. Read it together, then go outside.

WHO FOR Everyone
ACCOUNT None
OFFLINE Jot the highlights on paper
`www.rmg.co.uk/stories/space-astronomy`

5 Code Club projects

Free step by step coding and making guides from the Raspberry Pi Foundation. [7] Code Clubs are free for all school aged young people. [8]

Ask your school or library about a club near you.

WHO FOR School aged young people
ACCOUNT Not to read the guides
`projects.raspberrypi.org`

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

Where this came from

1 **Micro:bit Educational Foundation**, MakeCode. `tech.microbit.org`
2 **Micro:bit Educational Foundation**, MakeCode screen reader support, 13 July 2026. `microbit.org`
3 **Scratch Foundation**, Scratch, frequently asked questions. `scratch.mit.edu`
4 **Scratch Foundation**, About Scratch. `scratch.mit.edu`
5 **European Space Agency**, ESA Kids. `esa.int`
6 **Royal Museums Greenwich**, Night sky highlights, October 2026, 29 September 2026. `rmg.co.uk`
7 **Raspberry Pi Foundation**, Learn. `raspberrypi.org`
8 **Code Club**, Code Club. `codeclub.org`

THE FAMILY EXPLORER

The Family Experiment

Seven days of checking

One small check a day. Tick a circle for everyone who joins in.



Bloop says
Saturday is the best day. You get to fool everyone, kindly.

MON
Who made it?
Find one picture and work out who made it.

TOGETHER ○ ○ ○

TUE
Spot the mistake
Play hide a mistake from page 3.

OFFLINE ○ ○ ○

WED
Ask a question
Ask a grown up how they check things.

OFFLINE ○ ○ ○

THU
Invent
Design your fake detector on page 5.

OFFLINE ○ ○ ○

FRI
Send a true thing
Finish the postcard on page 7.

OFFLINE ○ ○ ○

SAT
Real or Pretend
Play the card game on page 9.

OFFLINE ○ ○ ○

SUN
Show and tell
Share the best question you asked this week.

OFFLINE ○ ○ ○

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

Our best question

What fooled us

What we will keep doing

THE FAMILY EXPLORER

Cut out and keep

Your Planet Passport

Collect a stamp for every activity. Colour each circle in once you have done it.



PLANET PASSPORT

Issue 002, The Real or Pretend Edition

Stamps are collected by doing things, never by buying them.

EXPLORER

FIRST NAME ONLY

- **Mistake hidden** PAGE 3
- **Detector** PAGE 5
- **True thing** PAGE 7
- **Detective** PAGE 9
- **Explorer** PAGE 10
- **Seven days** PAGE 11

SIGNED OFF BY A GROWN UP

DATE

SAMPLE · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

Next month · January 2027

To be planned

- Chosen at the next research week

A LITTLE MORE WONDER. A LOT MORE UNDERSTANDING.

Every source in this issue

Each page lists where its facts came from. The full list, with links, is online.

www.guidedchildhood.com/guided-planet/issue-002/sources

For grown ups

The Guided Planet is made by The Guided Digital Childhood. We help families get children to sixteen ready for a phone and social media, ten minutes a day, together.

What stage is your child? Three questions, no sign up.

www.guidedchildhood.com/starter-pack

The Guided Planet

SAMPLE. A structure test: this issue proves a second edition is made from words alone. Its story pages are placeholders.

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DECEMBER 2026
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